



Subin Joseph
Head of Office
printing Solutions,
HP Inc., APJ

On a different tone

We try to understand how HP goes about the printing business

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Q Could you give us an overview of HP's overall strategy?

Subin: HP's core strategy is a very simple strategy. We look at the world from Core, Growth and Future. Our core products are our printing and PC franchises. That is what the core of HP is all about, especially after we split as a company and our core technologies continue to drive and grow our business for us. As we look at it, we also look at businesses from a growth perspective. These include, the A3 business which is an adjacency. As you know, HP is the world no. 1 for printing in A4 whether it is inkjet or laserjet. HP has a significant portion of market share and we're clearly the leader there. So for us to extend that franchise and go to the adjacent A3 market has been a relatively simple step. And the way we made the entry into the A3 business was thus. First of all, we worked our own technology, we launched the HP pagewide array technology which is HP's core IP. Secondly, we acquired the Samsung Printing business which had a lot of A3 technology. Therefore, we got the laser IP there. Combined with these two technologies, we believe that we have the world's most comprehensive product lineup and solutions. So that's the growth from a printing perspective.

There are also growth sectors within the PC business. One such area is gam-

ing in AP. There's been a lot of work we've done there and we've gained a significant share in the last one and a half years. If we look at the growth, then our growth focus is around how we provide experiences to customers and what we can see from megatrends is that it's all about AI, it's all about AR. So we're working on what we call "our immersive computing strategy" is how we use AR as part of the overall computer experience. And the other vector for the future from HP is of course, 3D printing. So Core, Growth and Future is HP's basic way of looking at how megatrends will impact our customers.

I mentioned earlier that we acquired Samsung's A3 printing business a year and a half back. We also launched our Pagewide Array Technology. Also, in 2015 we launched a technology called Jet Intelligence. What this technology basically did was, it really helped us reduce the power consumption on our devices by 53%. And the way it does that it by focusing on the material technology of the toner. We created something called low-melt core which melted the toner accurately and correctly at a much lower temperature. So we save a lot on power. The Jet Intelligence technology helped HP become one of the most efficient engines for printing in the market. And that really helped us from a customer perspective because for them, environment friendliness, power consumption and the economics around that is very important.

Q Would we see the pagewide array coming to the SMB printers in the future?

Subin: The Pagewide technology is basically about a single print bar. And that print bar is stationary and it's the paper that moves. That print bar has 42,000 nozzles and the economics are such that unless there is a high-volume of printing, it will not make sense. So to bring it down to home printing, we don't see it at this point of time.

Q When you look at printer cartridges, the refill market is huge. As a company, you'd want to retain control over the cartridge market so you add security features which can be cumbersome to the customer if there's excessive implementation. How do you achieve a balance between not compromising customer experience while retaining control?

Subin: The experience is always better when you use original cartridges. So the way we look at the customer experience is what is their total cost of print. This is calculated using the hardware acquisition cost, supplies cost as well as the services cost. We have some industry benchmarks. For India, there would be a certain Rs/page that we would try to achieve. Therefore, when we design products we have those benchmarks in mind to be able to attain those without having customers feel the pinch. This is why we also get into areas like CSS (Continuous Supply Systems), especially for high-volume and really low cost printing, we provide ink-tank solutions. 